The government of Brazil attaches high importance to support for companies like Vale. The large amounts of credit conceded by BNDES and other public policies set up to support and facilitate the global investments of Brazil's multinationals are seen as fully justified. The activities of these companies are portrayed as advantageous for Brazil as a whole. The argument is that through these 'global challengers' Brazil increases the entry of foreign exchange (through deposits of profits), increases its exports, broadens its insertion into chains of global innovation, as well as the effects on suppliers to these companies, who also increase their production (Alem and Madeira 2010).

This narrative is squarely within the neoliberal paradigm. A country that wants to gain a hegemonic position globally is in need of big companies. Despite their ownership by private interests and notwithstanding their open espousal of high profit levels that guarantee good returns to their directors and shareholders as their main objective, Brazil's big companies and their global expansion are treated as synonymous with Brazil's 'national interests'. Worker or community or citizen resistance to the operations of these companies, whether at home or in global operations, is readily categorised as criminal action (Garcia and Fontes 2014).

Does this much-heralded ascent of the BRICS to the elite club of global powers really encompass the national interests of all citizens of Brazil? Do all Brazilians experience Vale's success as a 'global challenger', as cause for celebration? Does every Brazilian think that Vale's ability to enter the vicious competition between the global giants in the world of big mining means that Brazil has 'arrived', that it can now stand tall, hold up its head, proudly taking its place in the G20 with the 'developed' countries of the North?

To assume Vale's success and Brazil's national interests as synonymous is to operate within an old discourse about development that sees the transition of the nation-state from agrarian to industrial societies as the task, with the state as the main actor, the national society as the main target of development planning, and foreign direct investors as the key source of capital for these development goals of employment, modernisation and economic growth to be realised.

Perhaps multinational corporations from the BRICS are better understood by stepping outside this old development discourse based on territories and situating them instead as players in a new global discourse based on flows. This is a world where there is a fully articulated transnational economy with flows of capital, information, technology, equipment and even land, labour and private security forces (Sikor 2013). All of this global economy operates outside the logic and largely outside the regulation of national jurisdictions. A big mining company